They weren't alone in seeking such a re-classification. Other OBC communities in Category II(a), such as the Kuruba and Vishwakarma, want to be included in the ST list while the Ediga community has for years been seeking a shift to Category I. Leaders of the Vokkaliga community—which is currently in Category III(a) with 4 per cent reservation—have threatened a stir from January 23 if their demand for a hike to 12 per cent isn't met.

On December 29, the Bommai cabinet, citing an interim report of the Karnataka State Backward Classes Commission, approved a rejig of the OBC categories in a bid to accommodate both the Vokkaliga and Panchamashali demands. It did away with their existing categories [III(a) and III(b) respectively] and instead created two new categories—II(c) and II(d)—but kept their reservation quotas intact. The rationale for the move, as law minister J.C. Madhuswamy explained it, is that these new categories will also have accrued to them whatever is bound to remain from the separate 10 per cent quota for the Economically Weaker Sections (EWS). "In principle, we have decided to distribute what is left over from the EWS reservation quota to II (c) and II (d) for educational and employment purposes. We will finalise it when the data is available," he told the media on December 29.

BOMMAI IS SEEKING TO ACCOMMODATE DEMANDS FOR A HIGHER QUOTA FROM ONE SET OF LINGAYATS AS ALSO VOKKALIGAS VIA THE SURPLUS FROM EWS

"There is no clarity yet, so we are unable to react immediately," says C.N. Balakrishna, president of the Vokkaligara Sangha and a Janata Dal (Secular) MLA from Shravanabelagola.

KERALA/ CPI(M)

CLEANING HOUSE OR A PURGE?

By Jeemon Jacob

It all started at the CPI(M) state committee meeting on December 22 that unanimously passed a 'rectification charter' aimed at weeding out "undesirable characteristics" and elements within the party. The document, with a typically stone-faced title ('Contemporary politics and the party's immediate responsibilities in the organisational sector'), charts out a plan to, ostensibly, improve the quality of leaders and cadre. Explaining to the media, CPI(M) state secretary M.V. Govindan Master said, "Corrective steps will be taken and no one will be exempt. From the state secretariat to the lowest unit of branch members, all party workers will be subject to an elaborate process of self-criticism and scrutiny."

Those terse lines speak of a degree of inner tumult the party does not usually admit to. If sources are to be believed, a purge cannot be ruled out. The 69-year-old Govindan Master had replaced the deceased Kodiyeri Balakrishnan as state secretary in September 2022 and is known as a strict disciplinarian. The state committee meeting had witnessed dramatic moments after senior leader and current Khadi Board vice-chair-



ANI